Lesson 41: Pathos and Ethos

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 5.4 Identifying and Using Pathos; 5.5 Identifying and Using Ethos.

In this lesson

You look closely at two of the three rhetorical appeals. You learn why stories and sensory images affect readers (with brain research that connects to your psychology course), how to find pathos and ethos in texts, and how to build your own credibility as a writer without misusing it. Then you add pathos and ethos to a body paragraph of your argument.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain how pathos affects readers, using the brain research in the lesson.
- Find obvious and less obvious examples of pathos in a text.
- Evaluate ethos: is the writer fair, expert, and using trustworthy sources?
- Build ethos in your own writing and avoid misusing it.
- Add pathos that fits the subject: vivid description, metaphors or similes, short narrative examples.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
EM·pa·thy	understanding and sharing another person's feelings	"to see with the other person's eyes, to hear with another's ears ..."
metaphor	describing something as if it were something else (a simile does this with "like" or "as")	"The singer had a velvet voice."
show, don't tell	give details so the reader can "see" the situation	visible cracks in the wall
mirror neurons	brain cells that are active both when we feel something and when we watch others feel it	Our brains mirror other people's pain, fear and disgust.
sincere	honest; really felt	using pathos effectively and sincerely
cred·i·BIL·i·ty	the quality of being trusted and believed	Ethos is about credibility.
au·THOR·i·ta·tive	sounding like a trustworthy expert	present your argument in a way that sounds authoritative
hedging	careful words that limit a claim	may, perhaps, appear to

Rules and explanations

What is pathos?

- Pathos connects writer and reader through emotion, senses and story. The goal is empathy: readers "see our point of view" because they feel connected in their minds and hearts.
- The book quotes a 1930 definition of empathy, "to see with the other person's eyes, to hear with another's ears, to feel with the heart of the Other." It is usually attributed to the psychologist Alfred Adler (the book prints "Albert Adler").
- As readers, we look for these "roads to our hearts" and decide whether the writer uses them effectively and sincerely.

Pathos and the brain

Research reported in the book	Finding
reading any words (Annie Murphy Paul, "Your Brain on Fiction", New York Times)	Two small areas are active: Wernicke's and Broca's areas, which interpret and produce language.
Carnegie Mellon University, 2014: subjects read Harry Potter in an fMRI (functional magnetic resonance imaging) brain scanner	When a character walked, the reader's motor cortex lit up as if they were walking; when characters talked, areas for thinking about other people's motivations and recognizing faces were also active.
Emory University	Sensory metaphors ("The singer had a velvet voice", "He had leathery hands") activated the sensory cortex; phrases with the same meaning ("a pleasing voice", "strong hands") did not.
a Dutch Science Foundation article	We activate common circuits when we observe others' sensations or emotions and when we feel them ourselves ("mirror neurons").

Using pathos

- Persuasive writers, politicians and advertisers use pathos to make us feel angry, afraid, hungry, protective and passionate.
- "Show, not tell": give details so that the reader can see the situation in their "mind's eye". This works in an argument as well as in a novel.
- Even formal academic writing may connect to readers' feelings. To evaluate pathos, ask: does the text arouse the audience's interest and sympathy?
- To add pathos, use vivid, specific description and imagery; metaphors or similes; short narrative examples. Pathos is not always appropriate: probably not in a science lab report.

What is ethos?

- An appeal to ethos is about trust. The word means "character" and is related to ethics.
- A source may be credible because of their education, profession or official status, or because of personal experience (like a garment worker protesting about factory safety).

- As a reader, ask: Are they fair? Are they experts on the subject? Are they using other trustworthy sources?

Building your own ethos

1. Present your argument clearly, so that you sound authoritative and professional (a strong thesis).
2. Do not exaggerate the strength of your claims; hedging language can make your position sound thoughtful and reasonable.
3. Explain and respond fairly to opposite or alternative positions, so readers see that you have considered the full picture.
4. Use evidence from trusted sources, cite them accurately and give their credentials.

A model: Luz Claudio, "Waste Couture"

The annotated excerpt in 5.5 shows how Claudio builds ethos: she gives a credential for her source ("Susan Strasser, a professor of history at the University of Delaware"); she zooms out to a larger cause (economic growth depends on marketing new products) instead of blaming foolish consumers; she makes a concession ("Yet even today, the journey of a piece of clothing does not always end at the landfill"); and she names the source of each statistic.

When writers misuse ethos

Ethos is important, but it can't stand alone.

1. A support sentence looks like evidence, but it only repeats the writer's point in the words of a credible source. It depends on who said it and builds no logical argument (Exercise 3).
2. Writers (especially marketers) focus on who endorses a product or idea rather than on what is good about it, often with a person who is not even an expert. This is the logical fallacy called appeal to authority or appeal to false authority.

> **Psychology note:** Research reports in psychology (APA style) use almost no pathos. Like the science lab report the book mentions, they persuade with ethos and logos: credible sources, careful claims and data.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Persuasive writing in Arabic often uses repetition and strong, emotional wording for emphasis. Translated directly into an English academic argument, this can sound exaggerated and weaken your ethos; one precise detail, a credible source or a carefully limited claim persuades English academic readers better.

Practice

Exercise 1. Finding pathos. Read "Corporate Social Responsibility and Sweatshops" (Jimenez and Pulos) in your lesson material (5.4). Look for obvious and not-so-obvious examples of pathos. List at least six words or phrases, and say what feeling or image each one creates.

Exercise 2. Finding ethos. Read "The Other Side of the Story: In Praise of Sweatshops" (Jimenez and Pulos) in 5.5. Look for the ways the authors establish ethos for themselves and for the sources they cite. Find:

1. a credential;
2. two places where the authors are fair to the other side;
3. at least four hedging words or phrases;
4. evidence from research or history.
5. Then say what makes the ethos of this passage weaker.

Exercise 3. Misusing ethos. A writer wants to support this claim: **Producing fabric causes damage to both the environment and society.** Here are three possible support sentences with evidence from a credible source. Which one misuses ethos? Why?

- A. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, these harms range from "the growth of water-intensive cotton, to the release of untreated dyes into local water sources, to worker's low wages and poor working conditions" (Bick, et al.).
- B. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, "The environmental and social costs involved in textile manufacturing are widespread" (Bick, et al.).
- C. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, this damage is not always easy to see: "The human and environmental health risks associated with inexpensive clothing are hidden throughout the lifecycle of each garment" (Bick, et al.).

Exercise 4. Ethos in a thesis. Here is the thesis of "Deadly Fashion" (Lesson 40): "Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions, it has devastating impacts on labor rights and the environment, and needs serious regulations by all nations to stop the damage."

1. Which part of the thesis builds ethos, and how?
2. Following the book's advice not to exaggerate the strength of your claims, rewrite the thesis so that it sounds more careful.

Exercise 5. Show, don't tell. Paragraph 3 of "Deadly Fashion" gives specific details about garment workers in Bangladesh. Use some of them to rewrite this plain sentence with pathos, and cite the source: *Garment workers in Bangladesh have difficult working conditions.*

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my lists for Exercises 1 and 2. Did I miss any examples? Is each one really pathos or ethos?"
- "Here is my body paragraph: [paste]. Where could I add pathos? Does my pathos feel sincere, or exaggerated?"
- "Role-play a skeptical reader. Ask me the three questions about my sources (Are they fair? Are they experts? Are they using trustworthy sources?), and I will defend them."
- "The book connects pathos to fMRI studies and mirror neurons. Let's discuss what my psychology course says about this research. Ask me to explain it in my own words."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each | mark.

1. Our goal as writers | is also to build EM·pa·thy.

2. "The singer had a velvet voice" | and "He had leathery hands" | roused the sensory cortex.
3. An appeal to ethos | is all about trust.
4. It's not always appropriate to use pathos, | depending on the subject and assignment.
5. Ethos is important, | but can't stand alone.

Writing task

Add pathos and ethos to your argument. Use the topic and introduction you wrote in Lesson 40. Write one body paragraph of 200-250 words that supports your thesis:

- a topic sentence with one reason for your position;
- evidence from at least one credible source, introduced with a credential and cited;
- one element of pathos that fits the topic: a short narrative example, vivid specific details, or a metaphor or simile;
- one sentence that is fair to the other side, or one claim limited with hedging;
- an explanation that connects the evidence to your thesis.

Then copy the paragraph and label each appeal in [brackets], as the book does with Claudio's text.

Self-editing checklist:

- My pathos is vivid and specific, and it fits the subject and assignment.
- My pathos is sincere, not exaggerated.
- Each source has a credential and a citation, and each one is credible.
- My evidence adds something more specific than my topic sentence; it does not just repeat it in an expert's words.
- I represent the other side fairly.
- I use hedging where my claim is stronger than my evidence.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The full chapter by Jimenez and Pulos, "CSR and Sweatshops", from Good Corporation, Bad Corporation (the source of both readings): https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation/chapter/9-csr-and-sweatshops/
- Bick and colleagues, "The global environmental injustice of fast fashion" (Environmental Health, 2018), the source of sentences A to C: https://doi.org/10.1186/s12940-018-0433-7

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer)

- Obvious: "trapping and killing over 1,100 employees" (horror, sympathy); "the worst industrial disaster in the history of the garment industry" and "the world's most fatal industrial building collapse" (shock); "Rescue workers struggled for over a week to reach trapped survivors" (tension, fear); "many with severe injuries" (pain); "Survivors told heart-rending tales of having lost mothers and sisters" (grief; readers think of their own families); "The deaths of so many innocent workers" ("innocent" creates sympathy and anger).
- Not so obvious: "ominous warning signs, such as visible cracks in the wall" (a visual image; anger at the owners who ignored them); "creating a weight the building could not bear" (a physical image of the collapse); "well-known Western brands, such as Walmart, Joe Fresh, and Mango" (readers may shop there: guilt and a personal connection); "a firestorm of controversy" (a metaphor of fire); "intense and profound soul-searching" (moral feeling); the exact date and place at the start (it opens like a story and makes the event real).

Exercise 2 (example answer)

1. Economist Jeffrey Sachs is "perhaps the world's foremost expert on the eradication of poverty (he was the creator of the United Nations Millennium Project to cut global poverty in half)".
2. "In light of the above history, it might seem startling that ..." (they remember the abuses described earlier); economists "concede that sweatshop abuses are both common and reprehensible"; China "is still in a transition phase and reports of sweatshop abuses are still common".
3. Any four of: "might seem", "appear to accept", "perhaps", "In general", "most economists", "appear to confirm", "in most countries", "A number of countries", "appears to be following".
4. "One study revealed that, in most countries where the presence of sweatshops had been reported, apparel factory workers actually earned more than the average national wage"; "Some international research studies appear to confirm the economists' point of view"; the historical examples of the United States, Japan and Korea.
5. The research studies are not named or cited, so readers cannot check them; and the Sachs quotation is from 1997, so it may be out of date.

Exercise 3 (book) B misuses ethos. It is at the same level of specificity as the claim: it only says the same thing again, written by a credible source, so it depends on the source's credibility instead of building a logical argument. A and C both add something new and more specific (A names the harms: water-intensive cotton, untreated dyes, low wages and poor working conditions; C adds that the risks are hidden throughout each garment's lifecycle).

Exercise 4 (example answers)

1. The opening clause, "Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions", shows that the writers know the other side and treat it fairly.
2. Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions, its serious effects on labor rights and the environment suggest that stronger regulations are needed in the

countries that make and buy cheap clothing.

Exercise 5 (example answer) For ten to twelve hours a day, garment workers in Bangladesh typically breathe in fabric dust, work in extreme heat and suffer repetitive motion injuries from their machines; one machine operator told researchers, "We sew shirts with our tears and injure our fingers due to needle punctures" (qtd. in Akhter et al.).

My notes